

Texas WIC Health and Human Services Commission

Effective August 1, 2025

Policy No. GA:25.0

The Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality

Purpose

To create a warm, friendly, welcoming, and respectful environment that promotes positive health outcomes for WIC clients.

Authority

7 CFR 246

Nutrition Services Standards, USDA, August 2013

State Policy

Policy

1. All WIC staff must utilize The Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality when interacting with WIC clients and co-workers.
2. Local agencies must maintain a WIC clinic environment that is clean, safe, and supportive of breastfeeding, with client-centered services that promote positive health outcomes for WIC clients.
3. All interior and exterior clinic improvements must align with the Texas WIC Design Guidelines and Catalog.
4. Local agency and state agency leadership will set the tone for Texas WIC Hospitality through modeling, guidance, and support.

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Definitions

Client-Centered WIC Environment - the atmosphere and services provided within a clinic setting that are respectful, accommodating, and promote the health and wellbeing of WIC clients.

The Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality - a set of behaviors that WIC Staff perform every day to create a friendly and welcoming environment for WIC clients and co-workers.

Procedures

- I. All WIC staff must utilize The Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality and apply the following practices when interacting with WIC clients and coworkers:
 - A. Greet and address clients by name in a warm and friendly manner.
 - B. Assist clients with belongings as needed.
 - C. Value all clients and coworkers with dignity and respect.
 - D. Engage by actively listening to the client to provide helpful and credible information and resources tailored to their needs.
 - E. Close conversations with a client in a warm, friendly, and thankful manner.
 - F. See clients at their scheduled appointment time, or keep clients informed of any delays.
 - G. Be present in front of clients by not using personal cell phones.
 - H. Show respect to clients by not gossiping or engaging inside conversations.

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- I. Create clinic spaces that are neat, clean, and family-friendly.
(Refrain from posting unnecessary papers and flyers which create a cluttered clinic environment.)
- J. Be proactive at resolving issues in the client's best interest.
- II. WIC Staff must demonstrate the following behaviors in each area of focus:
 - A. Professionalism
 - 1. Interact with WIC clients and co-workers in a courteous and respectful manner.
 - B. WIC Policy Compliance
 - 1. Adhere to WIC policies and procedures.
 - 2. Seek clarification of WIC policies when needed.
 - C. Communication
 - 1. Listen actively, attentively, and seek to understand the perspective of others.
 - 2. Voice opinions and suggestions in a respectful manner.
 - D. Teamwork
 - 1. Work cooperatively with others to achieve WIC's mission, goals, and objectives.
 - 2. Assist others as needed to efficiently serve WIC clients.
- III. Local Agencies must establish a clinic environment that supports a client-centered experience.
 - A. Display outdoor and indoor WIC signage to enhance the client's ability to locate WIC clinics.

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- B. Utilize WIC branding that is current, clean, and relevant. Ensure that the use of artwork and WIC logos are in line with WIC branding.
- C. Discontinue use of bulletin boards for nutrition education lessons. Bulletin boards may be used to display relevant information such as *And Justice for All* and *Fair Hearing* posters.
- D. Ensure that restrooms are clean, sanitary, and accessible to individuals with disabilities. Include a diaper changing area in the restroom or other area of the clinic as space allows.
- E. Work with property management as needed to ensure the WIC environment is in appropriate operational condition.
- F. Label biohazard containers for medical waste clearly and keep all hazardous items out of the reach of children.
- G. Arrange desks and chairs to remove physical barriers and allow for knee-to-knee conversation. Use appropriate social distancing as needed.
- H. Design clinic flow to reduce wait time, enhance efficiency of WIC services, and support positive interactions between clients and WIC staff.
- I. Ensure all equipment for hematology, weighing and measuring is in good working order, so accurate measurements may be obtained.
- J. Protect privacy and confidentiality in all areas where client information is obtained.
- K. Offer age-appropriate activities for children throughout the WIC clinic to help facilitate communication between WIC staff and parents/caregivers.
- L. Avoid negatively worded signage such as no cell phones, no food or drink, etc.

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- M. Answer phone calls and emails promptly.
- N. Accommodate the client's individual traditions and/or customary practices.
- IV. Local Agencies must ensure a breastfeeding-supportive clinic environment.
 - A. The clinic must be set up to encourage and help mothers feel comfortable breastfeeding their infants anywhere in the clinic. A private, comfortable space must be available to mothers who prefer privacy while breastfeeding.
 - B. Prioritize breast pump issuance and breastfeeding support to clients in need by providing same day appointments whenever possible.
 - C. Provide empathetic support to breastfeeding mothers who request formula as outlined in the Infant Feeding Counseling Tips job aide.
- V. Local Agency leadership (WIC Directors, Supervisors, etc.) must support The Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality:
 - A. Set the tone for the Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality through modeling, guidance, and support to all staff.
 - B. Provide ongoing opportunities for WIC staff to reflect on the Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality and provide input on ways to enhance the clinic, work environment, and other WIC services to provide a positive WIC experience.
 - C. Monitor all sites to ensure that the elements of the Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality are implemented. This includes providing positive feedback to staff as warranted and addressing staff performance issues when not consistent with hospitality practices.

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- D. Address facility and/or clinic environment issues posing a danger to WIC staff and clients as soon as possible.
- E. Take action based on client feedback from the Your WIC Experience Survey.
 - 1. Best practice: customer service tickets are read and addressed (change status to "in progress" or "closed," with notations in the follow up section of the ticket) within 24 hours (1 business day).
 - 2. Acceptable: customer service tickets are read and addressed (change status to "in progress" or "closed," with notations in the follow up section of the ticket) within 72 hours (3 business days).
 - 3. For complaints involving discrimination, a 24-hour response is required.
- VI. The State Agency must support The Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality:
 - A. Set the tone for the Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality through modeling, guidance, and support to all staff.
 - B. Provide positive support to local agencies with implementation of client-centered services that are in line with The Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality.
 - C. Monitor the clinic environment and other WIC services to ensure The Essentials of Texas WIC Hospitality are implemented at all local agencies.
 - D. Offer clients the opportunity to provide anonymous feedback on the clinic environment and other WIC services. Provide this feedback to the local agencies.

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- E. Respond to local agency and client concerns based on prescribed time frames listed in section V. (e).

Policy References

- Policy No. CR:06.0 Provision of Services to Individuals with Disabilities
- Policy No. GA:01.0 Confidentiality of Applicant/Participant Information
- Policy No. BF:01.0 Breastfeeding Promotion and Support Standards
- Infant Feeding Counseling Tips/Providing Empathy and Support When a Breastfeeding Mother Requests Formula- Stock no. 13-06-115222